INDIA TODAY SMART MONEY FINANCIAL SUMMIT

THE LAST-

The India Today Smart Money Financial Summit had top experts disc

By M.G. Arun

For a first, the India Today Smart Money Financial Summit, held in Mumbai on April 12, could not have had a more eminent galaxy of leaders and experts. They came from across the financial services spectrum—banking, mutual funds, insurance, stock markets and real estate. Delivering the keynote address, 'Disruption as the new norm in financial services', V. Vaidyanathan, MD & CEO, IDFC First Bank, elaborated on how new technologies such as generative AI, blockchain and hyper-personalisation are helping reach financial services to the common man. Digitisation, he said, can be used to create insights, which is one level above information. It is also cost-effective for banks and helps reduce paperwork. His bank, he said, found that it needed 28 pieces of paper for a microfinance loan of Rs 25,000-30,000. If one million loans are given, 22 million pieces of paper will be required. "Our executives are now using tablets. All documents are digitally acquired and uploaded. Disbursal of loans is also digital," he added. And the bonus? The lower cost is passed on to the customer.

Taking that theme forward, the session 'A changing landscape: Technology & innovation in financial services' had Rajiv Anand, deputy MD, Axis Bank, talking about the all-round optimism about the economy. "The government and RBI handled Covid-19 well, the fiscal health is better, unlike the US where the fiscal deficit is at 8 per cent (of GDP)," he said. Manisha Girotra, CEO, Moelis India, said global investors were more upbeat on India than we are. "We have a young population and an up-skilled and re-skilled workforce. We have the potential to become an R&D hub, move up the value chain in several businesses."

Delving into some of the solutions for the unmet financial needs of today's customer, especially women and rural customers, was the session 'Driving transformative changes in financial services'. Talking about the increasing interest in mutual funds, Narendra Mairpady, former CMD, Indian Overseas Bank, said banks took advantage of the liquidity and RBI's lowering of interest rates during Covid to provide very low fixed interest rates. Fund managers, in turn, used this advantage to tell investors to opt for mutual funds, which explained their surge. However, Ridhi Doongursee, co-founder, LXME, rued that while women were fabulous savers and budgeters, they did not plan their own finances well.

They would have done well to tune into what Nilesh Shah, MD, Kotak Mahindra AMC, told audiences in the session titled 'Indian stock market: Outlook and opportunities'. The Sensex touching the 75,000



▲ DISRUPTION AS THE NEW NORM IN FINANCIAL SERVICES

> **"India is becoming a pioneer in open banking, where banks can share your information with a financial services provider or bank who can analyse your information and decide if they can give you good quality financial advice or loan"**
>
> **V. VAIDYANATHAN**
> MD & CEO, IDFC First Bank

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